overladen with steel utensils negotiating cracks in the paving.

Inside, as the minutes deepen, the service gets more fervent. It's a small hall with peeling plaster. A young man on a keyboard, using a delivery that mixes song with spoken-word exhortations, paints pictures of salvation from a tiny stage curtained with pink lace. A dozen women sit in rows on one side, dupattas around their heads; a handful of men on the other. Weather-hardened faces, farmhand attire. They know when to pick up the tempo with their clapping, when to dial it down—very reminiscent of qawwali. A woman sings through the youth's spoken-word rapping, hallelujahs morph into a rustic chorus, simple lines sung in a shrill tone not unlike what you hear at a jagaran. The lyrics are similar too, all about the seeking and receiving of *dua*; they could belong to any religion. The pastor is a benevolent shepherd, sitting, joining in the clapping, moving around, keeping an eye. The posters on the walls feature him. In one, he's a turban-clad cop blessing newly-weds. In another, he's in a cassock, minus turban, with two white women in salwar kameez: the legend says 'Bethel Masih Satsang'.

A majority of the flock are from Punjab's 9 most exploited communities: Mazhabi Sikh -Balmiki, Sansi, Rai Sikh, Bawaria, Bazigar, Barad, Bangala, Gadhile and Nat

SPREADING THE FAITH

Meet the new pastors of Punjab. A disparate bunch, strung along two polarities. There are the dozen-odd major pastors—Amrit Sandhu, Kanchan Mittal, Raman Hans, Gurnam Singh Khera, Harjit Singh, Sukhpal Rana, Faris Masih—with big flocks, multiple branches in Punjab, stage acts right out of the TV evangelist playbook and YouTube followers in the millions. They cover all walks of life: doctors, engineers, advocates, cops, bureaucrats, businessmen and landlords who have either quit their professions or double up as Sunday preachers. Also, the caste spectrum. Some miles away from Khambra, in village Khojewal, Kapurthala district, the Open Door Church, with its East European Protestant architecture, catches your eye: its spiritual meister, Harpreet Deol—who offers guests boiled eggs along with tea ("*tussi ande khao*")—is a Jat Sikh. So is the surgeon-pastor Gurnam Singh Khera at Harpura village, off Batala. Mittal, with her Church of Peace in Banur, Patiala, is a Baniya. And Hans of Chamkaur Sahib is Mazhabi Sikh. Many of them have their status embellished by private security:







Deol's office is guarded by big-built bouncers and a fingerprint-enabled security lock.

At the other end of the scale are the village pastors, with their humbler horizons and Sunday sermons often hosted in a portion of their own house. If Sehnsra's Gurnam Singh is an ASI in Punjab Police, Manohar Singh of Naraingarh, Amritsar, was a small cloth merchant, pastor Gajjan Singh was a farm labourer at Attari, and Dalbir Masih a small-time tailor in Verka. They take freely from Punjab's cultural markers—turban, langar (they call it Jesus da langar), the tappa song, the gidda